

Chapter 1 Leader Nationalism: Theoretical Foundations and Data Sources

Abstract

The literature on nationalism relies on a few historical cases and emphasizes the role of the masses in national independence movements. These tendencies impose two limitations. First, mass-based analyses start a step beyond the events that precipitate such conflict; political leaders are positioned to instigate ethnicity-related violence initially. Second, although its qualitative approaches are instrumental in highlighting the particulars of the masses' armed struggle, they struggle to identify generalizable patterns. To address these limitations, I urge researchers to bring state leaders back into the study of nationalism and security affairs. In this chapter, I offer a theory of leader nationalism and discuss how to operationalize this concept. I argue that when political leaders legitimize their regime through nationalism, they are predisposed to engage in or provoke four forms of political violence: ethnic terrorism, ethnic conflict, irredentism, and interstate conflict. I propose two nationalism measures that enable the discovery of generalizable patterns in data on interactions among nationalism, state leaders, and the four violent forms.